The Evolution of Jalen Duren's Offensive Profile

A Breakdown of Offensive Growth

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Introduction

Three seasons removed from a 14-68 campaign, the Detroit Pistons have undergone one of the league's most dramatic turnarounds, evolving from a rebuilding roster into a legitimate contender atop the Eastern Conference. After exceeding expectations with a 44-38 season and a first-round appearance against the New York Knicks in 2025, Detroit entered the 2025-26 season with continuity, internal development, and a clear upward trajectory.

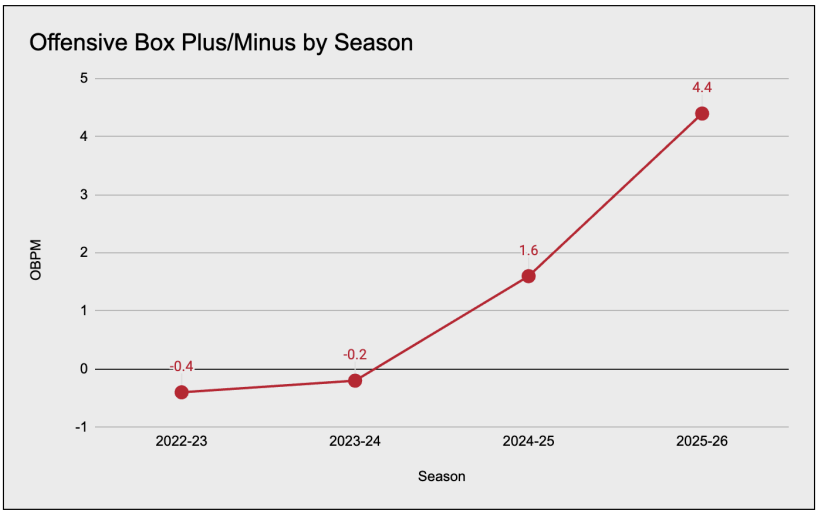
This rise isn't tied to any single factor, but rather a combination of organizational growth: Cade Cunningham continuing to develop as a primary initiator, a young core benefiting from another year of shared experience, and the cultural and schematic identity established by head coach J. B. Bickerstaff. Cunningham's availability has also played a role in shaping the team's offensive structure; after missing 18 games this season, his absences created extended opportunities for others to take on primary offensive responsibility. Within that broader context, the emergence of Jalen Duren has been a critical variable. His offensive leap has not only solidified his role as the franchise's long-term anchor at center, but also raised the team's overall ceiling as a secondary offensive option.

From a front office perspective, the decision not to extend Jalen Duren during the summer of 2025 appears to reflect organizational patience rather than hesitation. General manager Trajan Langdon has shown a tendency to avoid making premature long-term commitments, instead prioritizing a larger sample size before solidifying key pieces of the roster. That approach is especially relevant in Duren's case, as he was not drafted by Langdon, making a more measured evaluation process both logical and necessary.

That evaluation window, however, proved to be brief. Early in the 2025-26 season, Duren's expanded offensive responsibility and production quickly clarified his trajectory, making it evident that he is not just a complementary piece, but a foundational contributor within a system built around a cohesive, developing core.

The statistical progression supports that conclusion. Duren's Offensive Box Plus/Minus, a possession-based estimate of offensive impact, has trended upward each season, with a particularly sharp increase from 2024-25 to 2025-26 (see Figure 1).

Figure 1



In 2025, Jalen Duren averaged 11.8 points per game on an elite 69.2% shooting, attempting 7 field goals in 26.1 minutes per game. By 2026, that production jumped to 19.5 points per game on 65% shooting, with his volume rising to 11.5 attempts in 28.2 minutes. The combination of increased usage and sustained efficiency highlights a significant offensive leap, one that ranks 2nd among all qualified players in year-over-year scoring increase (behind only Nickeil Alexander-Walker). Duren isn't simply capitalizing on more opportunities; he's operating in a more demanding role within the offense, handling greater volume while expanding the ways in which he generates scoring.

The scale of that leap firmly places him in the Most Improved Player conversation. But raw numbers alone don't capture the full picture. The more important question, and the focus of this analysis, is not whether Duren has improved offensively, but what's driving that leap and how it's showing up on the floor.

Increased Offensive Role and Usage

A primary driver of Jalen Duren's offensive leap is a clear expansion in role and on-ball responsibility within the Detroit Pistons' offensive system. Usage rate and possession involvement data (Figures 2 and 3) illustrate a meaningful shift from a low-to-mid usage finisher in 2024-25 (ranked 20th among centers) to a secondary offensive hub in 2025-26 (6th among centers). Rather than operating primarily as a play finisher, Duren has been integrated more directly into the team's offensive initiation and continuity actions, effectively functioning as a 1B option alongside Cade Cunningham.

This shift is most evident in his volume metrics. Duren is attempting 6.8 more field goals per 100 possessions compared to last season, a substantial increase that reflects both schematic trust and expanded offensive responsibility. Importantly, this is not empty volume, his increased involvement is paired with sustained efficiency, indicating that his role has scaled without compromising offensive effectiveness.

Figure 2

2025 Pistons USG% Leaders

Player	Pos	G	MPG	USG%
Cade Cunningham	PG	70	35.0	33.2
Jaden Ivey	SG	30	29.9	26
Malik Beasley	SG	82	27.8	22.5
Dennis Schröder	PG	28	25.2	19.6
Marcus Sasser	PG	57	14.2	19.4
Ausar Thompson	SF	59	22.5	19.1
Ron Holland	SF	81	15.6	18.1
Tobias Harris	PF	73	31.6	17.6
Jalen Duren	C	78	26.1	16.4
Simone Fontecchio	SF	75	16.5	15.8
Tim Hardaway Jr.	SG	77	28.0	15.5
Isaiah Stewart	C	72	19.9	12.4

Figure 3

2026 Pistons USG% Leaders

Player	Pos	G	MPG	USG%
Cade Cunningham	PG	64	33.9	30.5
Jalen Duren	C	70	28.2	23.6
Daniss Jenkins	PG	72	20.2	21.5
Paul Reed	C	65	13.9	20.6
Ron Holland	SF	78	19.9	18.9
Tobias Harris	PF	63	27.7	18.8
Caris LeVert	SG	60	19.2	18.4
Kevin Huerter	SG	25	20.5	18
Ausar Thompson	SF	73	26.0	16.9
Isaiah Stewart	C	58	22.7	16.6
Duncan Robinson	SF	77	27.4	15.8
Javonte Green	SG	82	17.6	14.8

From a physical and stylistic standpoint, Jalen Duren's 6'10", 250-pound frame remains a foundational advantage, but the most meaningful change lies in how frequently, and where, he is being utilized within the offense. His overall touch volume has increased by approximately five touches per

game compared to last season, with a notable rise in frontcourt involvement (roughly +4 frontcourt touches per game). This reflects a more intentional effort by the Detroit Pistons to feature Duren as a consistent option within their half-court offense.

The situational breakdown of those touches further underscores his expanded role. Post-up touches have tripled from 0.4 to 1.2 per game, signaling a greater emphasis on leveraging his size and strength as a scoring and decision-making advantage. Similarly, his paint touches have increased from 7.9 to 10.6 per game (1st among all qualified players), pointing to more frequent involvement in interior actions and sustained presence in high-value scoring areas. These increases point to not just more opportunity, but more intentional deployment within the offensive structure.

Equally important is how Duren has handled this added responsibility. His ability to maintain, and in many areas improve, his scoring efficiency while operating with increased volume shows that he is handling a larger role without sacrificing effectiveness. More importantly, this expanded involvement points to something beyond just more touches or opportunities, it suggests a shift in how he is creating offense, not just how often he is involved.

From Finisher to Creator

That distinction becomes the natural next step in evaluating his development: is Jalen Duren simply doing more within the same offensive role, or is his offensive profile fundamentally changing? The data clearly supports the latter. While Duren's role has expanded, the way he generates offense has evolved as well, marking a transition from a predominantly dependent finisher to a more self-sufficient creator.

Play-type distribution (Figure 4) highlights this evolution. In 2024-25, Duren's offensive profile was heavily concentrated in putback opportunities, which accounted for 23.8% of his possessions, a clear indicator of a reactive, play-finishing role. In 2025-26, that dependency has decreased as his offensive portfolio has diversified, with measurable increases in isolation (+2.3%), post-up (+5.9%), spot-up (+2.6%), and cutting (+2.9%) possessions.

For this analysis, play types were grouped into four categories: "Create" (isolation, pick-and-roll ball handler, post-ups), "Finish" (putbacks, cuts, roll man, and other assisted actions), "Space" (spot-up, handoff, and off-screen actions), and "Transition." Using that breakdown (Figure 5), the change becomes clear: Duren's "Create" share has increased by approximately 8%, while his share of finishing actions has declined.

Figure 4

Play Type Evolution 24/25 -> 25/26

	Frequency (%)			Efficiency (PPP)		
Play Type	24/25	25/26	Diff	24/25	25/26	Diff
Isolation	6.2	8.5	2.3	1.02	1.05	0.03
Transition	16.1	13	-3.1	1.41	1.28	-0.13
Pick&Roll Ball Handler	2.5	2.8	0.3	1.35	1	-0.35
Pick&Roll Roll Man	16	15.3	-0.7	1.21	1.45	0.24
Post Up	3.8	9.7	5.9	1.23	1.22	-0.01
Spot Up	3.5	6.1	2.6	1.14	1.3	0.16
Cut	17.2	20.1	2.9	1.41	1.37	-0.04
Putbacks	23.8	16.4	-7.4	1.2	1.27	0.07
Misc	10.7	7.1	-3.6	0.2	0.42	0.22

Figure 5

Summarized Play Type Frequency

PlayType	2025	2026
Create	13%	21%
Space	4%	6%
Transition	16%	13%
Finish	68%	59%

This redistribution of offensive responsibility is critical. Rather than operating almost exclusively as a recipient of created advantages, Duren is now generating a portion of those advantages himself, whether through post positioning, face-up attacks, or controlled drives.

Shot location data further reinforces this transformation. In 2024-25, an overwhelming 79.5% of Duren's field goal attempts originated in the restricted area, reflecting a highly condensed scoring profile. In 2025-26 (Figure 6), that distribution has expanded outward, with increased volume in both the non-restricted paint and mid-range zones. While he is not yet a true floor-spacing big, this shift in shot distribution reflects a broader trend in modern offenses. Even interior players are expected to operate outside the restricted area at times, forcing defenses to account for them in more space and preventing the paint from becoming overly congested.

Figure 6

Shot Zone Evolution 24/25 -> 25/26

Zone	Frequency (%)			Efficiency (FG%)		
	24/25	25/26	Diff	24/25	25/26	Diff
Restricted Area	79.5%	68.2%	-11.2%	72.8%	72.8%	0.0%
In The Paint (Non-RA)	20.0%	27.5%	7.6%	54.1%	50.2%	-3.9%
Mid-Range	0.5%	4.2%	3.7%	100.0%	35.3%	-64.7%

Figures 7 and 8 provide additional context, illustrating a noticeable uptick in perimeter and face-up attempts. Even without elite efficiency from these areas, the willingness and ability to take these shots introduces new defensive considerations. Duren's improved coordination and ball-handling allow him to attack closeouts, navigate into short pull-ups, and create scoring opportunities that were largely absent from his game a season ago.

Figure 7

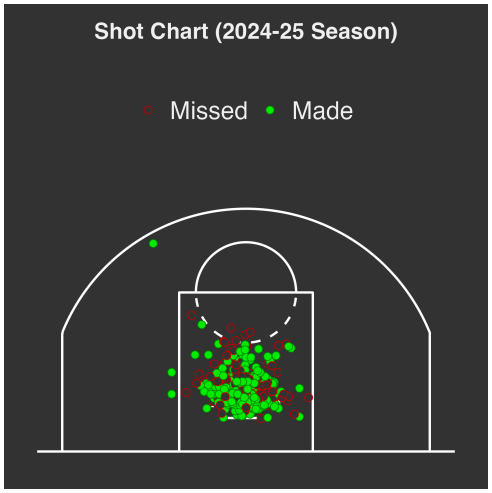
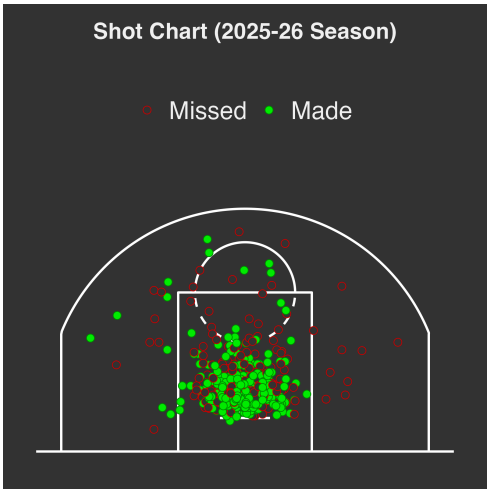


Figure 8



Shot-type analysis (Figure 9) offers perhaps the clearest evidence of this shift in offensive identity. Self-created opportunities have increased significantly, with driving layups accounting for a 10.5% higher share of his shot profile. Conversely, assisted and opportunistic finishes, such as putback layups, tip-ins, and alley-oop dunks, have all declined in frequency. His overall dunk rate has dropped

from 44% to 25%, while layups have increased from 40.5% to 52%, indicating a move toward more controlled, skill-based finishes rather than purely vertical, play-dependent scoring.

Figure 9

Shot Type Evolution 24/25 -> 25/26

		Season		
Shot Type 1	**Shot Type 2**	**2024-25**	**2025-26**	**Diff**
Layup	Running	2.0%	3.0%	1.0%
	Regular	4.2%	9.0%	4.8%
	Putback/Tip	16.5%	11.2%	-5.3%
	Driving	9.5%	20.0%	10.5%
	Cutting	6.0%	6.2%	0.2%
	Alley Oop	2.2%	2.7%	0.5%
Layup Total		**40.5%**	**52.2%**	**11.7%**
Jump Shot	Turnaround	1.1%	2.9%	1.8%
	Regular	0.9%	2.5%	1.6%
	Pullup	0.5%	3.0%	2.4%
	Floater	3.8%	6.4%	2.5%
Jump Shot Total		**6.4%**	**14.7%**	**8.3%**
Hook Shot	Turnaround	4.2%	3.5%	-0.7%
	Regular	1.1%	2.4%	1.3%
	Driving	3.7%	2.2%	-1.4%
Hook Shot Total		**9.0%**	**8.1%**	**-0.9%**
Dunk	Running	4.4%	3.1%	-1.3%
	Regular	4.2%	3.6%	-0.6%
	Putback/Tip	10.6%	3.7%	-6.9%
	Driving	3.5%	1.9%	-1.6%
	Cutting	6.4%	3.7%	-2.7%
	Alley Oop	15.0%	9.0%	-6.1%
Dunk Total		**44.1%**	**25.0%**	**-19.1%**

Taken together, these trends illustrate a meaningful evolution: Duren is no longer confined to the archetype of a traditional rim-running big; he is developing into a player capable of both finishing possessions and creating them. That added versatility significantly raises his long-term offensive ceiling within the Detroit Pistons' system.

Free Throw Generation and Efficiency

An important downstream effect of Jalen Duren's expanded offensive profile is a significant increase in foul pressure on opposing defenses. As his role has shifted from a low-usage finisher to a more dynamic and assertive scoring option, defenders are being forced into more reactive positions, often resulting in trips to the free throw line.

This is most clearly reflected in his free throw rate, which has jumped from 0.385 across his first three seasons to 0.535 in 2025-26. That level of increase is not marginal, it represents a fundamental change in how frequently Jalen Duren is generating contact relative to his shot attempts. In practical terms, his free throw volume has risen from 2.8 attempts per game across his first three seasons to 6.1 this season, a substantial jump that reinforces both his increased offensive role and a more aggressive scoring approach.

The source of this jump is particularly telling. Post-up efficiency and frequency (discussed in prior sections) have translated directly into higher foul rates. In 2024-25, just 10% of his post-up possessions resulted in free throws; in 2025-26, that figure has surged to 31.1%. This suggests not only greater volume in these situations, but improved physical control, positioning, and ability to force defenders into compromised states.

Equally important is what Duren is doing once he gets to the line. Free throw shooting, often a limiting factor for interior bigs, has become a relative strength rather than a liability. After converting at 69.1% through his first three seasons, he has improved to 74.7% in 2025-26. While not elite, this level of efficiency meaningfully alters the risk-reward calculation for opposing defenses.

The combination of increased foul generation and improved conversion creates a compounding effect. Defenders are less able to play physically without consequence, and fouling is no longer a reliable way to slow him down. In that sense, Duren's development in this area doesn't just add incremental scoring, it changes how defenses have to approach him, further reinforcing his evolution into a more complete and difficult-to-contain offensive presence within the Detroit Pistons' system.

Final Notes

For those closely following the Detroit Pistons, Jalen Duren's breakout is less a surprise and more a realization of previously observed potential. Early indicators were evident as far back as his rookie season, including a standout performance against the San Antonio Spurs in which he posted 30 points, 17 rebounds, and 4 blocks in an overtime win, an outing that sparked early comparisons to Dwight Howard due to his physical tools and interior dominance. What has changed since then is not just opportunity, but context: Duren is now operating within a more structured and functional offensive system, surrounded by complementary talent and guided by a coaching staff that is maximizing his skill set.

His development is also closely tied to the trajectory of Cade Cunningham, with the two forming a foundational pairing that defines Detroit's present and future. As the Pistons enter the first round of the 2026 playoffs, their ceiling will largely be determined by the scalability of this duo. If Duren's offensive growth this season is indicative of his long-term trajectory, the range of outcomes expands significantly, not just for him individually, but for the organization as a whole.

From a front office perspective, the decision not to extend Jalen Duren during the 2025 offseason has become a point of debate. In hindsight, his current level of production indicates Detroit will likely face a significantly higher financial commitment this summer than it would have a year ago. At the same time, that outcome is largely a reflection of Duren's own development, as he has clearly played his way into a more lucrative deal and earned the contract that now awaits him.

There's also a potential behavioral layer to consider. While difficult to quantify, it's reasonable to view Duren's contract situation as a source of motivation throughout the season. Without the security of a long-term extension, he had added incentive to elevate his play and establish his value, a dynamic that may not have existed to the same degree had a deal already been in place.

Regardless of the underlying factors, the outcome is clear. Duren has taken a substantial step forward, both statistically and stylistically, positioning himself as a core piece of the Pistons' long-term vision. The next phase, sustaining and building upon this development, will determine whether this season represents a peak or establishes a new baseline for an even higher level of performance.

Data & Methodology

All statistical data used in this analysis was sourced from Basketball Reference and NBA.com/stats, with additional data access facilitated through the NBA Stats API (nba_api Python package). Traditional and advanced metrics were primarily sourced from Basketball Reference.

Player tracking data, including touches, play types, and shot zones, was sourced from NBA.com/stats, with play-type data further grouped into broader categories for analysis. Shot chart data was accessed via nba_api and used to evaluate changes in shot distribution.

Shot-type analysis was supplemented by manual review of Jalen Duren's field goal attempts across the 2024–25 and 2025–26 seasons, with each attempt categorized based on the shot type recorded by in-game statisticians and grouped into broader categories to analyze changes in scoring profile.